

KEY FIGURE

GUSTAVUS
ADOLPHUS
1594–1632

King Gustav II Adolf of Sweden, known as Gustavus Adolphus, was an innovative tactician who emphasized the central battlefield role of the cavalry charge. From 1630, he intervened in the Thirty Years' War in Germany. Initially victorious, he later died in battle at Lützen, in 1632.



▲ Proud and aggressive, Gustavus Adolphus was dubbed “The Lion of the North”.

► CAVALRY AND ARTILLERY

The Battle of First Breitenfeld, in 1631, was a triumph for King Gustavus Adolphus of Sweden. It showed how effective cavalry could be when used alongside pike-and-musket infantry and artillery.



KEY DEVELOPMENT

FROM LANCE TO PISTOL

In the gunpowder age, cavalry lost their dominance on the battlefields of Europe. Fresh tactics had to be invented to restore a vital role to cavalry, working in combination with infantry and artillery.

At the start of the 16th century, European armies were still led by bodies of chivalrous knights, clad in elaborate armour, and employing the charge with couched lance (in the attacking position). Traditions such as jousting were also at the height of their popularity – as late as 1559, King Henri II of France died after a lance splintered against his visor in a joust. On the battlefield, however, infantry often prevailed, and horsemen with lances were rarely able to break up formations of pikemen.

Full plate armour was supposed to protect against firearms – breastplates were tested by the manufacturers by firing a ball at them – but this did not always work in practice. Its limitations were shown by the death of the renowned Chevalier de Bayard, in 1524, whose armour could not save him

when he was struck by an arquebus ball. The following year, the French aristocratic cavalry suffered at the hands of arquebusiers at the Battle of Pavia, in the Italian War. From the 1550s, however, heavier, bulletproof armour began to appear.

A NEW ERA

With infantry rising in status and the lance approaching obsolescence, new technology and tactics began to emerge. Mounted troops were unable to use matchlocks because these required two hands to operate, and they needed one hand to control their horses. However, the invention of the self-igniting wheellock allowed cavalry to use pistols. In the 1540s, the Reiters, German mounted mercenaries, adopted firearms and reduced their armour to a helmet, cuirass, and arm defence. For use against pike squares, they invented the “caracole”

► PROTO-MORTUARY-SWORD

Unique to Britain, “mortuary-swords” had a barred iron hilt to protect the hand. Some featured images of King Charles I after his execution in 1649, hence their modern name.

